

Dvar Torah Outline — Parashat Beha'alotecha: The Menorah's Light Facing North, and Illuminating the Yetzer Hara Through Torah

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman focuses on the Torah's instruction that all seven lamps of the menorah must shine “אל מול פני המנורה,” and he raises two questions: how this applies to the middle lamp, and why this detail appears here rather than earlier in the construction of the Mishkan's vessels. Drawing on Rav Tzadok, Rabbi Shulman explains that “מול” hints to the north side of the Mishkan—the spiritually vulnerable “opening” associated with the hidden yetzer hara (“הצפוני”). The menorah's light (Torah) must therefore shine “into the north,” elevating the שולחן (physical eating and enjoyment) into holiness and providing the only real antidote to modern excess and indulgence.

I. The core פסוק and two basic difficulties

A. The Torah's directive about the menorah's light

- Rabbi Shulman highlights the opening focus of Parashat Beha'alotecha:
 - “בְּהֶעֱלֶתְךָ אֶת הַנֵּרוֹת אֶל מוֹל פְּנֵי הַמְּנוֹרָה יֵאִירוּ שִׁבְעַת הַנֵּרוֹת” (When you raise the lamps, toward the face of the menorah shall the seven lamps shine.)

B. Difficulty #1: how do all seven lamps shine “opposite the face”?

- Rabbi Shulman notes the simple geometry:
 - Three branches on each side can angle toward the center.
 - But the **middle lamp** seems harder to fit into “אל מול פני המנורה.”
- The question models careful Torah reading: the phrase appears to include **all seven**.

C. Difficulty #2: why is the menorah's “construction idea” taught here?

- Rabbi Shulman (citing Rav Tzadok) asks:
 - Why discuss this now—**after** the נשיאים bring offerings and during Aharon's instruction—rather than earlier in the passages describing the building of the Mishkan's vessels?

II. “מול פני המנורה”: “מול” as the north side (2:31)

A. Locating the menorah in the Mishkan

- The menorah stands in the **south** (דרום).

B. Rav Tzadok’s key move: “מול” means opposite—i.e., north

- If the menorah is in the south, then “מול פני המנורה” points toward the **north** (צפון).

C. The north as the “open” side of the world

- Rabbi Shulman references Chazal’s description:
 - The world is shaped like a **ה**, with one side “open” (כאכסדרה).
 - That “opening” is identified as the **צפון**, a “צד הפרוץ,” an entryway for spiritual danger.
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III. “הצפוני”: the hidden yetzer hara (3:30)

A. “הצפוני” as a name for the yetzer hara

- Rabbi Shulman notes a teaching in the Gemara (Sukkah context): one name of the yetzer hara is “**הצפוני**.”
- The term suggests:
 - “צפון” as **hidden/concealed**, like a yetzer hara lodged within a person’s heart.

B. “זה לעומת זה”: seven names, seven counterforces

- Rabbi Shulman frames the struggle as parallel systems:
 - The yetzer hara’s “seven names” correspond to “seven positive abilities” (e.g., seven days), reflecting “**זה לעומת זה עשה אלקים**.”

C. “הצפוני” as the challenge of great people

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes that “הצפוני” is not a crude temptation alone:
 - It can be the refined, hidden danger that confronts **תלמידי חכמים** and **גדולי צדיקים**.
 - As long as humanity still bears the imprint of **נחש** (the aftermath of the serpent’s influence), this struggle remains relevant.
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IV. The “hidden” yetzer and the case of David HaMelech (4:30)

A. Even after inner cleansing, the yetzer may remain dormant

- Rabbi Shulman describes a person who has worked to remove worldly desires and replace them with רצון to serve Hashem (echoing the Mesillat Yesharim's ideal).
- Still, the yetzer may not be gone—only **hidden** (צפון וטמון), not encountered daily.

B. “לבי חלל בקרבי” as a model: דוד המלך

- Rabbi Shulman brings David's phrase:
 - “לבי חלל בקרבי” (My heart is void within me.)
- Even so, Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - At a moment of strong arousal (בשעת התעוררות / תאוה), the dormant force can “spring back up.”

C. The Torah's warnings about satiation and rebellion

- Rabbi Shulman notes the Torah's repeated pattern:
 - Descriptions of eating and being satisfied are often followed by warnings not to rebel against Hashem—because indulgence can open the door for the “צפוני.”

V. Why the שולחן is in the north, and what the menorah must accomplish (6:30)

A. Rav Tzadok: north contains the שולחן—physicality concentrated there

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - The שולחן הזה (with the bread) stands in the צפון, “מול המנורה,” because that side represents the realm of **food and physical enjoyment**.

B. Physical enjoyment is meant to be sanctified

- The שולחן has a זר הזה (a golden crown), symbolizing dignity and קדושה even in eating.

C. The mechanism of sanctifying the שולחן: the light of the menorah = Torah

- Rabbi Shulman identifies the menorah's light with **Torah**, invoking the idea:
 - Hashem created the yetzer hara and created its "spice/remedy," the Torah ("בראתי יצר הרע" "בראתי תבלין, זו תורה").
 - Therefore, "all seven lamps" shining "אל מול פני המנורה" means:
 - Torah-light must shine **into the north**, illuminating the place where physical appetite is strongest, transforming involvement in this world into holiness.
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VI. Contemporary application: excess indulgence and the only real antidote (8:00)

A. Rabbi Shulman's diagnosis of the moment

- He describes contemporary indulgence in food as extreme and "completely out of control."

B. The פתרון: "בהעלתך... יאירו שבעת הנרות"

- Rabbi Shulman concludes that the Torah's prescription is embedded in the pasuk itself:
 - raising the lamps so the menorah's light reaches "מול פני המנורה" (northward) symbolizes using **Torah illumination** to discipline and elevate our eating and worldly desires into קדושה.
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In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman raises two questions on "בהעלתך... אל מול פני המנורה": how it includes the middle lamp, and why it appears here in the narrative.
- Following Rav Tzadok, "מול" points from the south-placed menorah to the **north**, the "open side" associated with the hidden yetzer hara, "הצפוני."
- The שולחן in the north represents eating/physicality; it is meant for קדושה but is also a spiritual vulnerability.
- The **menorah's light (Torah)** must illuminate "into the north," serving as the true remedy that refines desire and brings holiness into everyday indulgence.